centric global system. In this system, in which the Bretton Woods institutions are dominated by the United States and some of its Western partners, the BRICs countries' calls for redistributive change had run into a brick wall of institutional rigidity.[14] The BRICS members, at that point, preferred a "voice" to an "exit" option.[15] Yet, although they wanted to be included among the directors and rule-makers, the incumbent major Western powers questioned their loyalty to existing global governance institutions, which eventually raised the prospect that the BRICS might experiment with competing institutional outlets. Successive communiqués at eight annual summits (2009–2016) have called for diversifying global reserves away from the dollar and shaming Western governments by noting that "international governance structures designed within a different power configuration show increasingly evident signs of losing legitimacy and effectiveness."[16]

Increasingly, the BRICS have acted jointly in international politics, to the consternation of many, especially policymakers in the West. Instead of symbolic "BRICS made without straw," the group has deepened and widened its cooperation, through time and despite leadership turnovers, for the last ten years. The BRICS expanded their club, admitting South Africa in late 2010 at the instigation of China. They invested in building new institutions, notably the BRICS Development Bank (now the New Development Bank, or NDB), a Contingent Reserve Arrangement (CRA), and the Chinese-initiated Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), in which the other BRICs are among the top shareholders. They successfully pushed the leading international financial institutions to implement stalled reforms that give the BRICS increased voting shares and decision-making influence broadly commensurate with their greater weight in the world economy. Despite pressure from Washington, the BRICS also hung together in the face of Russia's armed intervention against Ukraine and annexation of Crimea, opposing the Western economic sanctions that followed, and they have stayed together as China has acted more assertively, particularly in the South and East China Seas. And they have survived the synchronous economic slowdown in four of their five economies.[17] Improbably, so far the group has proven that the centripetal forces holding the BRICS in orbit are stronger than their differences and rivalries.